

Critical Response Questions

What are Critical Response Questions (CRE)?

- Critical Response Questions ask you to think deeply about a text, not just repeat it.
- You are expected to analyze, interpret, or evaluate ideas in the passage.
- Answers must include your understanding and evidence from the text.
- The focus is on explaining meaning, not just finding information.

How are CR Answers Different from Simple Answers?

Simple Answer

Gives direct information from the text.

Often short and factual.

Does not explain or analyze. A simple answer tells.

Example: *The author says happiness comes from relationships.*

Critical Response

Explains what the idea means and why it matters.

Uses evidence and explanation.

Shows your thinking and interpretation. A critical response explains and analyzes.

Example: *The author suggests that happiness is rooted in relationships, emphasizing that it is a shared experience rather than an individual pursuit.*

How to Answer a Critical Response Question

- 1. Understand the Question Type: Identify if it's interpretive, analytical, evaluative, contextual, or reflective (Do not mention the type of question while you are writing the answer).
- 2. Directly Address the Prompt: Restate or paraphrase the question to stay focused.
- 3. Support with Evidence: Use quotes, paraphrases, or specific examples from the passage. (“the concept of happiness.....mutual”)
- 4. Offer Insight or Interpretation: Explain why the evidence matters.
- 5. Be Clear and Concise: Use 5–6 well-structured sentences.
- 6. Use Academic Language: Employ precise verbs and logical connectors.
- 7. Stay Within Scope
- Avoid unrelated information.

Answer Structure

- Use the following structure to write your answer:
- Restate the Question
- State Your Main Point
- Support with Evidence
- Explain Your Evidence
- Link Back to the Question

The Algorithmic Mirror

In today's digital world, social media algorithms determine much of what we see, read, and believe. These algorithms, designed to prioritize engagement, often reflect not our best interests but our strongest reactions. The result is a mirror that shows us not who we are, but what keeps us clicking. The more we interact with content that provokes outrage, fear, or desire, the more we are fed similar content, creating what many call an "echo chamber." But this mirror doesn't just reflect, it shapes. It shapes our preferences, polarizes opinions, and sometimes distorts our perception of reality itself. The question we must ask is whether we are using technology or being used by it.

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- Do you agree that technology shapes what we see rather than simply reflects reality? Provide evidence from the text to support your opinion. How do you feel about the idea that algorithms influence our beliefs and emotions? Support your response with evidence from the text.

Sample Answer with Structure

Restate the Question

State Your Main Point

Support with Evidence

Explain Your Evidence

Link Back to the Question

The question asks whether technology shapes what we see rather than simply reflecting reality. I agree that technology, especially social media algorithms, shapes our perception instead of merely reflecting it. The text states that algorithms “prioritize engagement” and show content that provokes “outrage, fear, or desire,” creating an “echo chamber.” This means users are repeatedly exposed to similar emotionally charged content, which influences their preferences and strengthens certain beliefs. Instead of presenting balanced information, algorithms feed what keeps users engaged, gradually shaping how they think and perceive reality. Therefore, the text clearly supports the idea that technology not only reflects reality but also actively shapes what we see and believe.